



STARTUPS COMBATING COVID-19 WOES

INDIAN STARTUPS PROVIDING RELIEF VIA TECH-ENABLED INNOVATIONS

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There's a saying that goes, "necessity is the mother of invention". This couldn't be more true than now. With the daunting onslaught of the COVID-19 outbreak across the world, numerous Indian startups have taken on the mantle of providing solutions and innovations to combat the negative impact of the pandemic. In order to support the burdened health infrastructure, bolster the virus monitoring systems and provide utilitarian relief, startups in India have begun working closely with central, state and district level authorities. In fact, numerous government initiatives such as the government's Coronavirus WhatsApp chatbot were created by enlisting the assistance of Indian startups.

Additionally, established companies and brands have also begun forging alliances with Indian startups to keep the

momentum going for their businesses. For example, the supermarket chain, Big Bazaar joined forces with startups such as Rapido, a bike aggregator; and Scootsy, a food delivery service in order to deliver essential goods to Indian citizens. Consumer brands such as Marico and Tata Consumer Products Ltd are dependent on food delivery services such as Zomato and Swiggy for the delivery of their products via Zomato Market and Swiggy Genie. Tech innovators are also organising hackathons to develop ventilators, testing kits, apps for contact tracing, and contactless devices, among others.

The lockdown situation hasn't exactly been easy for most startups, with several startup founders and VCs in India requesting for relief packages from the government due to severe disruptions in day-to-day business. However, some startups, such

as edtech and telemedicine startups have seen a significant boom in their business. Nevertheless, many startups coming under non-essential services are facing economic turbulence. Additionally, startups in their infancy also face a bitter blow, with February already registering a 19-month low in investments. As per reports, fundraising has come to a near halt, with companies having to meticulously control their burn rate. Despite this, or incentivised by this, the Indian startups are kicking into high gear to come up with cutting-edge innovations. Here's a detailed look into some Indian startups that are innovating to combat issues caused by COVID-19.

ST AQU TECHNOLOGIES

Staqui, a Gurgaon based AI startup, has repurposed its AI-driven advanced video analytic solution,